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Denny Zeitlin

Pianist Denny Zeitlin was born in Chicago on April 10, 1938. He has gained critical acclaim as a composer and for his recordings that range from solo piano to electronic music. A long time San Francisco resident, Dr. Zeitlin currently maintains a thriving career as a psychotherapist, composer and pianist.

He was interviewed in San Francisco, California on August 8, 2002 by Monk Rowe, Director of the Hamilton College Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe and we are in San Francisco filming for the Hamilton College Jazz Archive. It's a real pleasure to be talking with Dr. Denny Zeitlin this afternoon.

DZ: Nice to be here, Monk.

MR: Thanks for fitting us into your — you probably have a busy schedule.

DZ: Very busy.

MR: I've been listening to your music for a long time and it always seems fairly experimental. Would you think of it in that manner?

DZ: I don't know about experimental. I do like to feel that I'm pushing my own envelope when I play, that I am reaching and trying to stretch the boundaries of what material I'm working with to try to come up with something fresh and to have it be organic.

MR: Organic. Okay. I know you work with the standards but you're also a composer yourself.

DZ: Yeah.

MR: When you do a recording, in the old days an LP and now CDs, the people you're working with, either producers or record companies, do they like to see well-known tunes on the recordings as well as your own material?

DZ: I think that's varied over the years, Monk. Like when I first started recording for Columbia back in the early '60s, John Hammond, who was my producer, liked very much the idea of recognizable tunes plus originals. And that's not an unusual stance for a producer to take. But over the years I've had projects where I've done albums totally of original compositions and albums all of standards, and I think it really depends on the record label, what their predilection is at the moment. I generally like to do mixtures because I think it's interesting to share with the listener what a musician does with a well-known tune in terms of how you might re-harmonize it or arrange it, and how you will work the changes of something they're familiar with. They have a place to stand to listen to the music. So sometimes it helps them get a foot in the door. An original composition offers the musician total carte blanche of the territory he wants to cover and that freedom

is wonderful but sometimes it's a little harder for the listener to get into. So having an album that has a balance of the two often I think is the best way to go.

MR: Jazz right now I guess sells about three percent of the —

DZ: Sounds like an optimistic percentage.

MR: Yeah, I guess three or less is what I heard recently.

DZ: Yeah.

MR: In your mind is there a reason that jazz is let's say more of a challenge for the listener?

DZ: Yeah. And I think our culture unfortunately as a large group is evolving more and more into a kind of attention deficit culture, so that people's attention span is for a sound bite, a quick image on MTV, a repetitive hook composition, whatever the genre. But to get someone to sit down and really sink into say a ten minute composition that has a number of parts and complexities and improvisation, a small segment of the listening population willing to reach out and meet the music halfway that way. It seems like people are willing to reach out this much, not that much, as a group. It's always a big treat when we play a concert or play in a club where people, even if they came in doubting what they were able to do, sometimes the positive contagion of a live event where some others are getting into the music will help other people reach out. But it's disturbing when I think of the culture at large, how rather than progressing in terms of being able to embrace complexity, the culture as a whole seems to be going in the opposite direction.

MR: Yeah. What's the number one cause of that in your mind?

DZ: I guess in some ways if there's a lot of material out there that sort of panders to the lowest common denominator, and there's a certain inherent laziness in people, if they can quickly get some fast food they may not want to sit down and have a beautifully prepared seven course gourmet meal. They'll just gobble and go on to the next.

MR: As if we're all so busy that we have to do that.

DZ: Yeah.

MR: You know the media says that they only reflect the culture or what people want. And critics of the media say I don't know, I think you're causing it to happen.

DZ: Sure, it's a very reciprocal kind of dance that goes on.

MR: Right. When you grew up in Chicago, can you recall the first — I know you came from a household that had a number of influences in it. What was the first music that made an impression on you?

DZ: My earliest? Like my earliest childhood—

MR: The earliest that you can recall.

DZ: It must have been something at home because there was a Steinway piano in the house from the day I was born and before. And so I imagine what I first heard was one of my

what I'm sure I heard first. My earliest experiences as a player was as an improviser. When I was about two or three years old, I still have dim memories of climbing up on the piano bench, often on the lap of whichever parent was playing, and I put my little hands on their hands and I would go along for the ride, kinesthetically, to get a sense of what it was like to traverse a keyboard. And then I would stay up there by myself and I would start playing stuff. And my folks gave me a tremendous gift by protecting me from formal study for a number of years. They sensed that I just needed time and space to just inhabit this musical world on my own terms and just improvise and make up things and do stuff. And then I guess when I was about seven years old I had a hunger at that point to formally study and that's when I began to study the classical literature.

MR: Yeah. They were very insightful then.

DZ: I think so. I think they did just the right thing for me.

MR: Yeah. Because if they had, you know, if they had tried to make you one of those four-year-old little prodigies it might have stifled you.

DZ: Yeah it could have. It could have been terrible for me. And there was another juncture where they again made the right decision. After a few years of studying classical music my teacher took my parents aside and said well now is the time you have to begin to groom your son for his classical musical career. He should be practicing six, seven hours a day. He shouldn't be playing baseball after school, he should be coming home and studying this instrument. And my folks looked at each other and thought about me and said enh enh, that's not for him, that's not where his heart lies. And they were absolutely right. I mean I have great respect and admiration for musicians who have the gene for the reinterpretation of the written page. I don't have it. When I studied classical music, as soon as I would learn a piece, all I wanted to do was to take that material structurally and harmonically and rhythmically and use it in my own music. The idea of keeping a formal repertoire up and ready to perform left me cold. I just had no interest in that.

MR: No kidding. By the age of — at what age did you kind of realize it, or was it always that way for you?

DZ: It was always that way. I would learn the music but then I would be using it in compositions and other kinds of stuff and improvising off of these.

MR: So if you were playing a piece of Bach, were you at the point where you could look horizontally down the music and recognize the chord structures and those kinds of things?

DZ: Not formally at the beginning. I didn't start really formally studying harmony probably until I was in maybe sixth grade. So it was more intuitive, what I was doing with the music. And even after I started to formally study harmony, my approach to the music has

psychiatrist and a doctor that gee that's a cognitively demanding pursuit, and I must be a real cerebral kind of guy. And it's really not very descriptive of me. My approach to the music, my approach to learning jazz was not a didactic one at all. It was like experiential, it was osmotic. I would go down to these clubs in Chicago and stay out until five in the morning and just soak it up. Grab a piano player after the gig and say, "come on, show me, what did you play, how did you voice that chord?" I mean that was how I learned this music. Not from some school. Not from some book. That didn't speak to me.

MR: Wow. Your parents were okay with you staying out 'til five in the morning?

DZ: Another gift from them. They really trusted me. I was tall, and in a dark room at age 15 I could pass for 21. And I had the requisite fake ID anyway. And so I would just go down to where the music was happening and I would stay out all night. It was a period in Chicago that was very open that way, this was like 1952, '53 is when I started hanging out at these clubs, and there was very little Jim Crow or Crow Jim. So I could be the only white kid in this club and nobody cared.

MR: No kidding.

DZ: You know they really welcomed somebody who loved the music and wanted to learn it. So it was a marvelous education.

MR: Most of these musicians that you would collar for a few hints, they were willing to—

DZ: I found everybody to be tremendously gracious and forbearing of my early attempts to sit in and play the music and stuff. I think Chicago had a wonderful vibe back in those days. I mean now of course we know there is jazz schools at every corner in every town. But there were none back when I was learning this music. This is the way you learned it, by an informal apprenticeship. That was the only way to get it.

MR: Right. And there's a lot to be said for that.

DZ: I think it's actually ideal for a music of this kind.

MR: Yeah you could actually get tossed out of the practice rooms in some of the conservatories — who said it, Don Menza said "playing swing was a misdemeanor and playing bebop was a felony." Oh gosh. Well did you come to a point ever when, in your late teens or whatever and maybe with your parents where you had a career decision to make? Was there ever a thought of trying to make a living as a jazz musician? And when did your interest in medicine start?

DZ: Well I think — I know that my music preceded my medical interest because I really was playing around at age two or three. But it was only a few years later that I started practicing psychotherapy without a license on the playground.

MR: Get out.

DZ: In second and third grade. I was fascinated with people and with families, what went on

talk to me about what was going on at home and what was bothering them and I would just listen. And I had a model early on, I had an uncle who was a psychoanalyst in Chicago. And he started talking with me about his work very early. And my mother had incredible psychological radar. She could just read people. Extraordinary sensitivity to nuances of emotional states, how people were put together. So those two influences were very strong in me. So early on I had an idea I wanted to be a doctor. My father was a doctor. I wanted to be a psychiatrist. I knew I wanted to play music. I didn't know exactly what shape my musical involvement would take or how public it might ever become, but I knew I was going to be involved in music all my life. But I didn't really set out, like in high school, that I wanted definitely to have any sort of big public career as a musician. I started playing professionally in high school, in jazz bands, and started sitting in. But I mean I didn't have big aspirations to start recording for instance. And possibly that was influenced by a number of musicians who were then on the scene and who were recording, who were telling me horror stories about record labels. About how their music was subverted. How they weren't allowed to play what they really wanted. How corrupt the marketplace was. So that there was a kind of atmosphere created that the really pure artistic thing to do was not to even bother with recording.

MR: Really.

DZ: So I didn't have big aspirations to record. All through college, I went to the University of Illinois where there were lots of opportunities to play with good people, I mean Jack McDuff was down there, Wes Montgomery was living in Danville at the time and I used to do some sessions with him and a wonderful tenor player named Punchy Atkinson, Joe Farintello, who changed his name to Joe Farrell, the tenor player who died all too young, a wonderful player. Roger Kellaway was playing bass then in and around the University of Illinois. So there was opportunity to play with a lot of good cats. And then when I went to medical school at Johns Hopkins in Baltimore, which was in 1960, I continued to get a chance to play and sit in in places. There was a place called the North End Lounge that was owned by Gary Bartz's father. So I started sitting in there typically on weekends and sometimes even during the week and playing with Gary. I just loved Gary's playing. And there were some wonderful players that used to play with him. So I got a chance to sit in and keep the music moving along. And then everything really changed dramatically in terms of a step into a more public kind of musical life in 1963. I had a fellowship at Columbia University in psychiatry, a ten-week fellowship. And so I was living in a little apartment that I was just renting for that time. And Paul Winter, who I had known from back in Chicago and had heard me play and liked my playing, who had just recently begun to record for Columbia, and he wanted to get together and I was visiting him at his

Hammond, he's a really wonderful guy. I'd just like to have him hear you play." I said, "oh, Paul, I don't want to get into that stuff. I really don't want to mess with you." "Come on, Hammond is different than all the rest."

MR: Yeah? Did you know John Hammond's name at the time?

DZ: No. I didn't know the significance until Paul then told me that he had discovered Benny Goodman and who else, Basie.

MR: And Dylan later and all that.

DZ: Yeah. Billie Holiday, Springsteen. So many folks. So sort of kicking and screaming he dragged me to Columbia to play for John Hammond. And so I played a few tunes and he said, "gee I really love what you play, I'd love for you to record for Columbia, you can come on in and play whatever you want, use whomever you want." And at that time I didn't know how extraordinarily lucky and unusual that was, so I just sort of slipped into recording in 1963, and so because Columbia was a powerful label and it got a lot of distribution and exposure, it just opened up a whole bunch of stuff for me overnight. So I might never have recorded perhaps if Paul Winter hadn't grabbed me by the ear and dragged me into his office.

MR: Were you known amongst your colleagues as — well gosh how do I say it — a little different, being that you had this other part of your life?

DZ: I think on both sides. Initially very early on some musicians, knowing that I was a physician and I was either studying to become a psychiatrist or after I'd actually become a psychiatrist, might say, "well gee, how serious is this cat about music?" And some doctors, not knowing me, might wonder well, "how committed is he to the practice of medicine if he's out there playing jazz in these clubs and making these albums?" But anybody who's gotten to know me has quickly understood how committed I am to both fields and how seriously I take them both. So it's really never been an impediment.

MR: Who were the pianists that affected or influenced your playing, or were there any?

DZ: Oh yeah. I mean I think most musicians start off being mostly affected by people on their instrument and then they expand their auditory interests. For me the very first jazz piano album I can recall hearing was an album my piano teacher brought me, it was a ten inch MGM LP called "You're Hearing George Shearing." And I remember hearing that album and saying woo, who is this guy? Listen to that marvelous classical technique and yet there's this wonderful rhythmic thing going and he's improvising, and I want to hear more of this music. And so I listened to a lot of Shearing then she brought in some Art Tatum and I listened to Tatum. I was drawn early on to Dave Brubeck, Lennie Tristano, particularly Billy Taylor for his consummate taste and touch. And in terms of pianists that I heard very early on and was greatly moved by I would have to say Billy Taylor

on the near west side. And again, because I was tall I could get in there, and I remember just spending nights listening to the Billy Taylor Trio and it just was wonderful music. Then I got a chance to hear Oscar Peterson at the London House in Chicago, which used to be a wonderful supper club. And I remember not only being knocked out by Oscar but even more so by Ray Brown, just the force and the drive of that playing, and I was thinking gee I hope someday I can play with a bass player like that. So I would say that those were my earliest pianistic influences along with Bud Powell. Because I heard Bud a little bit after I'd been listening to Billy Taylor and Bud knocked me out too. But then I very quickly was listening even more to Miles and to Coltrane and to Charlie Parker and I loved drummers and bass players and I'd played some bass, played some drums, played some high school and college type gigs on both instruments because I wanted to get an idea of what all the instruments were that play in a trio. And I enjoyed that very much. And then a big influence was George Russell as a composer and as a theorist. In fact when I think back over my career in terms of pivotal moments with certain musicians that were most encouraging to me and most galvanizing for me, I think of my relationship with Billy Taylor when I was just 15 or 16 years old, his graciousness. At one point my folks had his whole trio over to our home for dinner when they were in town. And I played some music with my fledgling trio for Billy. And they played for us. And it was just so warm and so encouraging, and I do remember his honestly saying that the life of an itinerant jazz musician was extremely arduous and that he had a telephone relationship with his wife back then. That was very painful. And he seemed to be saying be a doctor and enjoy your music. And through the years Billy has been an inspiration and a big support. When he first started doing some of his work as a DJ he would play my albums and stuff and then it was a big thrill a few years back to do a "CBS Sunday Morning" with him. So he's a wonderful man. Then I think of my relationship with George Russell when I was in medical school on this fellowship in 1963 where I got together with him and studied his Lydian concept. But even more than studying the specifics of his theory, the opportunity to hang out with George and to feel his excitement about music and his excitement about what I was trying to do, the support of that, was tremendous. And then there was a time after I finished my first trio album for Columbia, which was in 1963. This was an album called "Cathexis." I had read a review, a blindfold test that Bill Evans had done. And one of the tunes played for him was a tune from my very first album for Columbia where I was a featured pianist with Jeremy Steig. It was an album called "Flute Fever." And Bill had really liked my playing on that. So I felt enboldened to call him up when I was in New York and say, "Bill I've just finished this trio album, I've always admired your music tremendously, I would love to meet you and have you hear this, and I

invited me over and listened to the album, and was just beautiful about it. I mean Bill was always so comfortable with his own playing, I mean even though he was very self-critical, but he knew his playing. So he didn't have to be competitive with anybody, he didn't have to get into putting people down or anything. So he just encouraged me to do my thing. He said, "look I don't have anything to suggest except play your music. You're doing it. Just keep doing your music." And that was a tremendous encouragement from somebody, again, I had admired so much. So when I think back, the meetings with those three people at different points in my career early on was very, very inspiring.

MR: It must have been a nice feeling when he recorded your composition "Quiet Now."

DZ: "Quiet Now?" Well it was a nice feeling but it sort of amazed me. I mean I get impatient with tunes after a while. I mean I don't have tunes that I tend to play for 20 years or whatever. I mean I play them for a while and then I'll get into something else, whatever. So, and that goes for my own compositions. For some reason he never got tired of that tune. He kept it in his repertoire, and I'm told literally played it every night for 20, 25 years. Recorded it about eight or nine times. Can you believe that?

MR: That is amazing.

DZ: I mean I like the tune but come on.

MR: Yeah I like the tune too and I found it has been going in and out of my head today a whole bunch of times, knowing that you were coming here. And I was curious, I don't know if you can remember why you did this, but the idea of you had the first eight and then taking that up a whole step. How did that come about, can you recall?

DZ: I just think organically. That is just the way I heard it. It wasn't like hmmm let's do something unusual here, umm let's move it up a whole step. I mean that wasn't the way it happened. It just, yeah —

MR: Well I like it and I must admit that I myself have borrowed something you did in the last three measures of that thing which I think is really great.

DZ: Well I'm flattered.

MR: With the little phrase re-harmonized three different ways. I think that's just — I don't know there's something very emotional about the tune.

DZ: Thank you.

MR: That I think must be one of the reasons that he kept it on his playlist for so long. It does fit him well, I would say that. Why didn't you stay in New York?

DZ: I toyed with it. In some ways it would have been easier to keep a higher profile musical career going had I stayed in New York. But back then the vibe in New York I found too intense and oppressive. I have plenty of internal energy. I don't need that press from outside so much. And I hated the weather. I grew up in the Midwest with the extremes of

blisteringly hot, humid summers and cold, austere, windy winters. I wanted a temperate climate. So when I had a fellowship in 1963, before this one in New York, which was to go out to San Francisco to the Langley Porter Psychiatric Institute for the summer, I fell in love with San Francisco. The first night I was here I had rented an apartment on the top of Twin Peaks and I'm looking down over this whole city, and I'm thinking boy, I may never leave this place. And when it came time to apply for internship I applied to six hospitals in the San Francisco Bay area. Nowhere else. That was it. And I have never been sorry. I love living out here.

MR: This is the first time for me and I can see what you mean so far.

DZ: Yeah it's been just right, although certainly there is a sacrifice. If you live right in New York where all that foment is and there's a lot of business opportunities always, networking and stuff, it would have been easier to keep a higher profile going. But I really was more concerned with the overall quality that my life would have and the balance and trying to maintain a balance, and really at the hub of all of it I feel is my life with my wife Josephine. We've been together for 35 years. And that seems at the hub and then all these other things are, you know the spokes.

MR: Did you meet here while you were — let me do some math here.

DZ: I met her in '67. I actually met her at The Trident, a jazz club I had played for a number of years, in Sausalito, which is just north of the Golden Gate bridge. And she came into the club one night, I'm playing there with my trio. I saw her come into the room and I said to myself this is going to be the shortest set I've ever played in this club. And I made a beeline for this woman. And just a few weeks later we were living together. And it's been the best thing that ever happened to me in my life.

MR: That's nice. Your work in psychiatry, has it been mostly in hospitals or private practice or both?

DZ: Well in my psychiatric residency it included inpatient and outpatient work. But in private practice it's strictly outpatient. And so I do intensive psychotherapy with relatively healthy people. So I tend to work with them over a long period of time. They are people in the world, they are functioning well but they have psychological issues that they feel are getting in their way in some form, and our job is to help them remove those obstacles so that they can pursue their goals. And it's endlessly fascinating work. It never gets old.

MR: Has the practice of psychiatry — I was trying to make a comparison. To me jazz has moved at a dizzying rate, as far as it developing from one style to another and just what has happened in 50 years even. And I'm wondering if the practice of psychiatry has moved in that quick a rate.

DZ: Well there certainly have been a lot of happenings since I was a resident in the mid-60s.

psychiatric treatment, our understanding of molecular biology and genetics has grown by leaps and bounds, our understanding of what are the components in successful psychotherapy when you're talking with someone in your office, which is to a large extent it's the art of psychotherapy, but there is a scientific basis. And more and more there is research that really helps you understand how psychotherapy works. And I've been a member of a research group for 25 some years that's committed to studying the psychotherapeutic process in that way. It's exciting. It's very fascinating to see what it is that helps people change.

MR: You must have pretty highly developed listening skills. Does it —

DZ: I think so. I mean you get chops for whatever you do.

MR: Do you think it helps you in your playing in an ensemble situations?

DZ: I think so. I think sensitivity to all kinds of interpersonal dynamics can help you wherever you are I guess.

MR: I'm curious about, there seems to be a growing field of music therapy. You can actually study it in college. And is it something that you know about or you feel is an effective —

DZ: I've had very little experience with it, Monk. The experiences I've had mostly have been sort of self-designed and relatively informal in years past, not recently. I mean when I was in high school I would take my band into state mental hospitals and play for the people that were hospitalized there. So that's a form of music therapy, that it activated them, they enjoyed it, they danced around, they felt connected in some way. There was an event I did many years ago for the Esalen Institute in Big Sur, which was a creativity marathon, a 24-hour event which we videotaped and then had people bring soundmaking instruments and we did improvisatory games and exercises and videotaped them so people could get feedback and react to the tapes which would be taped and it was a complex 24-hour event, which was a lot of fun. Very exhausting. Never repeated. But an interesting foray into that area. I mean it is a recognized discipline with their own schools and accreditation and I have respect for it, but I've never been drawn to formally get into it. I think the major indications for music therapy with psychiatric patients tend to be with the relatively more disturbed sector of the psychiatric population, which I'm not really working with. You see it more in hospitalized populations or in halfway house or daycare centers. It would not be so much an ongoing modality that relatively healthy people would partake of on an ongoing basis several times a week. So what I'm involved in is a more intensive talking kind of therapy with people. It might still involve at times role playing, working with dreams and other kinds of things, but it doesn't involve dancing, playing music, doing those sorts of things.

MR: Do you think certain kinds of music can alter people's moods?

MR: If so, I'm wondering, you know sometimes we read about young people who have done something that their parents felt that they would never have done, and it gets blamed on the music they're listening to or the videos they're watching. Do you think that that is a reality?

DZ: You know this is one of the most controversial areas where people — there's a camp that says the increased violence of disturbed behavior is a function of people seeing it on the screen and hearing it in the lyrics of rock tunes and it just seeps into their psyche and they get the virus and they go do it. Or else they get desensitized to violence from seeing it as such a matter of fact occasion on a television screen so life becomes cheap. And then there's other people who point out that we don't have any definitive studies that actually show a cause and effect relationship here. So it's very controversial.

MR: How could you prove that? You'd have to subject someone — I don't know, I can't imagine how you would run a test to see if that — well one last question kind of on that subject — throughout jazz it's unfortunately been a lot of musicians connected with drug abuse and alcohol and so forth. Is there a reason for that other than the fact that a lot of times they make their living in bars and so forth. But is there other things that would make that come to pass?

DZ: I think there are other factors other than just the access and the social pressure of being part of a certain culture and to be like other people and the emulation of idols if they're using then you want to use as you are coming up. But I think the life itself, the nomadic, itinerant life, plus the pressures of standing up in front of an audience and doing an emotional strip tease night after night, for some people that's really quite threatening and taking various kinds of drugs may make it easier for them to get into that space. And I've known people, because of their own particular psychology, that clearly play better when they're on their drug of choice. And I've known people who, you know feel anxious and take the drug but then it erodes their sense of form so markedly when they play that what happens in that there's a lot of heat but not much light in their music. So I think there's quite a spectrum of people in terms of how they use their drugs. And for some people it really clearly seems to be adaptive for them. And for others it actually impedes their music.

MR: Yeah. I remember reading certain opinions about Charlie Parker that he would not have been able to play what he did if he had not been on heroin or something. And I hate to believe that. I just simply don't want to believe that, that that's where that creativity comes from.

DZ: Oh I don't think it comes from that. Again, I don't know how really the details psychologically of how he was put together. I mean if he were one of these people who

that process long enough to be able to tap into his creativity, then maybe it did facilitate the work. For the large majority of people, in my experience, it's been an impediment.

MR: Okay. Your work, composing work, in addition to "Quiet Now" of course, has appeared in some interesting places, including "Sesame Street" and "The Invasion of the Body Snatchers." How did that film come about?

DZ: The film opportunity came about through a back door, sort of analogous to the John Hammond story. It turns out that Phillip Kaufman, the director who made "Invasion of the Body Snatchers," was from Chicago and had heard me play years earlier, liked my playing, and had it in his head someday he wanted me to do a jazz score for one of his movies. So when "Invasion of the Body Snatchers" was just in the formative stages on the screenplay board, he called me and asked me if I would be interested in it, and at that time the protagonist, played by Donald Sutherland, was going to be an avocational jazz man. And so it was going to be very easy for that to be the legitimacy for a jazz score. But then as the script evolved he went from being a jazz player to a deputy public health officer, and now they wanted a twentieth century classical musical score and electronics and everything. And I had no established credentials for doing that at all. So I had to convince first Phil that I could do it, and then a much tougher sell was to convince his producer, Bob Solo, that I could do it. I think if I had been in Solo's position, I wouldn't have taken a chance on me. This was then a quite expensive movie, five or six million dollars in 1978 was significant money. And I think I would have been tempted to go with an established pro who had credentials where I wouldn't have to wonder whether this guy's going to mess up the film. But Phil was so adamant about wanting me, and then when I was — I think Bob Solo's sort of graceful way of hoping I wouldn't do it was to make me such an insulting offer that I would walk away in a huff. But I wanted to do this. I was willing to do it for nothing, for the experience. So —

MR: You called his bluff.

DZ: I called his bluff. I took it. And then it turned out because of the way the movie was constructed and all the different instruments I was playing, I was playing all kinds of electronic keyboard instruments and all this stuff and just the way you legitimately bill for services in union contracts, I ended up —

MR: Oh because of the doubling –

DZ: Tripling, quadrupling – with a fair amount of money. So the irony was I ended up being paid really quite well, and I had this unique experience of bringing to bear everything I had ever done in music, or wanted to do. Because I wanted someday to write for an orchestra and figured it's never going to happen, when will I ever have the time to do this, or access to an orchestra to play it. And here I had a ten week period to get this thing

notice — the patients knew about it and nobody got in any trouble, but it was a big step for me to close my office for five weeks and then have it open for five weeks half time, so I had some time over a ten week period to work on this score, which was tremendously demanding. Because I was writing for a full symphony orchestra for the first time, plus overdubbing electronic instruments and effects on that symphonic performance. So I'd go down to L.A. There's be a symphony orchestra that would play the piece. I would take the tapes back to San Francisco and I'm sitting at the ten voice Prophet synthesizer, which was state-of-the-art.

MR: Yes. I had one.

DZ: It was going out of tune every cue and I'd have to turn it off until it cooled down and turn it on again, right?

MR: Isn't that amazing?

DZ: Do you remember?

MR: You think it's so primitive now.

DZ: Then it was the cat's meow. So I was using that and all these other keyboard stuff and overdubbing on those tapes. It was a dizzying procedure. And I remember I mean I was working 18 to 20 hours a day on this. My wife would come down sometimes at two in the morning and scrape me off the piano stool, drag me upstairs and dump me into the hot tub to reconstitute. I mean it was something. And so when it was over I was thrilled to have had the experience, to get a soundtrack album out of it and everything. But it was so exhausting, plus some of the political and interpersonal things that happened towards the end involving actually getting paid, I said once was enough. I'm lucky to have done it, I'm lucky that I did get paid because they wanted a soundtrack album bad enough so money had to be forthcoming. I said quit while I'm ahead. A series of one. So when I got other offers to do it I sent them on.

MR: No kidding. I would have been very anxious going in front of a symphony orchestra of L.A. musicians, being it was the first time that you'd done that.

DZ: Well what I did is I was realistic. I amassed a wonderful team. And here I have to really thank Roger Kellaway, who had been doing movie scores for a number of years down there, and I called Roger and I said, "look I've got this opportunity, I don't know a damn thing about how Hollywood works with this stuff, who do I need here?" So it ended up Roger conducted the orchestra for me, because I'd had no experience conducting at all, I got Greg McRitchie to do the orchestration, because he was a seasoned orchestrator who didn't have an ego, so he didn't have to feel he had to change any note. So I wrote out, in the orchestral sketch, every note that I wanted to hear, but Greg made crucial decisions that I was not qualified to make which would be, I might say I want brass here, but he

trumpets be playing this same note an octave higher? He was a master orchestrator. Did a beautiful job. And I had a top musical editor who prepared the timing sheets for me so I knew just exactly to a tenth of a second how much music was needed in every scene. And a top contractor. So I had a super, super team, the best LA musicians, because again Roger told me all the guys to hire. And I had the best studio, a guy named Dan Wallin in the Burbank Studio, this was the top soundstage. So for a guy doing his first film, I had this Rolls Royce opportunity. And I knew I could do another hundred films and it would never be that good. So that was it man.

MR: Okay. You cannot reproduce that so just concentrate on something else.

DZ: Don't look.

MR: That's great. How have your playing opportunities been since you moved out here? Do you get enough to keep you satisfied?

DZ: Yeah. I mean it's — again it's about a balancing act that I've had to accept all my life because I'm gripped by these two interests. It's always some measure of compromise when you try to do something like this. So I have felt that my task has been very much defined, what is at the heart of each field for me? So if I can find the filet mignon of jazz and of psychiatry then I have my best chance of being really happy. So I've renounced certain activities on both sides. In psychiatry I don't do any administrative work. I do virtually no committee work or organizational psychiatric work. I don't do any inpatient psychiatry. I don't work with patients who are likely to be calling me at four in the morning dangling from the Golden Gate bridge because they're intensely suicidal. So I work intensively on an outpatient basis with people who I know are healthy enough to be able to keep themselves going but have legitimate psychological issues they want to work on. I love to teach so I teach at the medical school in the Department of Psychiatry, I teach residents how to do psychotherapy. And I'm involved in this research group I mentioned to you which is very fascinating and I teach under their aegis. And I consult to other therapists' practices and kind of help them if they get snarled up with certain patients. So that's the heart of psychiatry for me. I don't spend time writing papers. I've written a few but that's not where my heart lies. In music, what I really love to do is I love to compose, I love to have a certain amount of performing opportunities and I love to record and do a certain amount of international touring. But it doesn't make sense that I would expect that I would be out every weekend playing or making four albums a year or touring ten months out of the year the way some of my musical friends do. That's absolutely not possible. What I try to do is to find a way to be with music every day in some fashion. So I try to get my hands on the keyboard every day. And it might only be for an hour or so. When I'm preparing for a tour or preparing for a recording then it really

not get to the piano at all if I'm really immersed in some psychiatric stuff. But I try to keep my hands in and my ears open and to do enough performing so I'm feeling I am sharing the music with people, which is a very important experience. There's something so wonderful that happens when you're in the proper setting with the proper musicians and the music is really happening and you begin to have this merger experience with the music where boundaries dissolve, the music is just happening, I feel like I'm just a conduit for the music. I know the audience is out there and it's then like we're all in the audience listening to this music. When that happens it's just exquisite. I mean I wish I could say it happens every time I play. It doesn't. But the times it does happen, you try to let it happen. Because you can't consciously grab it, but you try to find out what sorts of emotional states and preparation can you do that will invite that experience. So the performing really can be super special.

MR: Wow. Well said. I had a question and you just made me forget it. That was so interesting what you were saying. Do you have people that, in your opinion, would be considered to be musical geniuses? I think that personally speaking the word genius is bandied about an awful lot. And I'm wondering, in the people that you enjoy listening to over the years, have there been a couple that you would consider to be geniuses?

DZ: I agree with you that the word is so highly charged and it would be so difficult to define. I mean I do think, when I think of the real incredible innovators and trailblazers in our music I tend to think of people like Charlie Parker, Bud Powell, Miles Davis, John Coltrane, George Russell, Ornette Coleman, people like that. I think — Wayne Shorter is another huge giant in my view in terms of a kind of unique contribution to the music over a long period of time. I'm sure I'm leaving out people that I love. Because there's so many people that I admire. But those are some people that at least at this moment leaped into the foreground when I think of major, major people.

MR: Okay. If I was to look — I'm assuming maybe you have a shelf of CDs or LPs.

DZ: So many I couldn't begin to catalogue them.

MR: Who would I find a lot of there? Who would I find?

DZ: Oh you'd find all those people I mentioned plus hosts of other players. I mean I feel I've been able to learn and get something from listening to virtually everybody I've ever purchased a CD or LP of. And I have quite a voracious appetite for just a wide range of music, unusual ethnic music too, classical music ranging from Bach all the way to the most modern atonal kinds of things, and some rock & roll I like a lot and funk bands and electronic music. So there's an awful lot of music I love a lot.

MR: I know you went through a few years or a period where you were doing some prepared piano music.

DZ: Um hum. There actually was a whole decade that I was immersed in a kind of a multiple keyboard integration of classical, rock, jazz, funk and electronic music. It started in the late 60s, around '67, '68. Well before there were any kind of polyphonic synthesizers around or even portable monophonic ones. It was maybe just as the ARP 2600 was coming out. Mainly it was Moog synthesizers with patch cords and stuff. And I got engineers to build me modules and things and ring modulators. And I gradually put together a rig that looked like a 747 cockpit. Six different keyboard instruments in stacks at right angles to each other, miles of cords and foot switches and foot pedals. It took six hours to tear this thing down from my studio, load it onto a truck, take it to a gig, play the gig and then six hours to undo it. But I loved it. For about ten years this was the way I performed and recorded. I did several albums of this kind of stuff. And it actually was at the time of my leave taking with Columbia Records. They didn't want to embark on this particular journey with me and I can't blame them. It didn't have much commercial potential at all. So I put out the first album myself on Double Helix Records. And so for about ten years I was doing a lot of that kind of work, and that period really culminated with this "Invasion of the Body Snatchers" score in '78. So it was about a ten year period. And when that was over I'd not only had had enough of movie scores, I had a hunger for the purity of acoustic music. And for many years I did almost no electronics at all, just acoustic piano in various contexts. And it's only in this last year that I'm currently involved in a very interesting project with a synthesist and a recording studio guy named Pat Gleason, very talented guy. He was, you may remember he was the first synthesist to go on the road with a jazz group.

MR: With Herbie Hancock, right?

DZ: Right. And so Patrick and I have known each other for a long time. In the 60s he was the guy who first told me to take this cord and plug it here when I wanted to learn what a Moog synthesizer was about. So we're doing a project together, just totally on spec which is kind of a piano concerto orchestral format where the orchestra is synthesized. And we're having a ball. It's my first big foray back into electronics in many years.

MR: Yeah. The toys have changed a lot.

DZ: Oh yeah, the toys changed. It's just amazing what's out there now. And I'm very glad to have someone who is immersed in it as thoroughly as Pat is, because it would be very hard now to do all the music and all the electronics and all the recording yourself. I mean God—

MR: You think back what a Prophet cost when it was in its heyday. For the same amount of money now you could get an awful lot.

DZ: You can indeed and yet it still ends up people like Pat who have studios like this, it's a

library known to man, and every kind of hardware bus and all the software and microphones. It's endless. And it's a full time commitment to know how to use a studio like that. He's constantly reading the updated manual for this latest software that's got five hundred pages of these — so it's a huge commitment these days to be up on that stuff. So to me it makes sense to collaborate with someone like that. He brings that to the table, I bring the composition and the performing to the table. And I think something very interesting is happening.

MR: Great. I don't know if this question is answerable in the short form. But is there something that makes one person more able to learn improvising than another? Or be less afraid of it?

DZ: It's a good question. I mean I do believe that there is a certain inborn talent for improvisation that helps a person if they're interested, if they can draw on that genetic advantage that's helpful. But an awful lot of it I think is interest in it, access to opportunities to learn it, permission to have that experience, and not having any kind of psychological obstruction that gets in the way of allowing yourself to enter that terrain where improvisation is possible. And the kinds of psychological issues that frequently do get in the way of people doing that are people that have big issues about losing control, that have tremendous need for structure and reassurance that what they're doing every moment is right. And it's one of the things that makes it very hard for classical musicians to make a transition into also being able to improvise, that they might play a wrong note, how do you know? You have all these possibilities. What makes that note better than another? And they can be paralyzed by that.

MR: Right.

DZ: Sometimes people who have a lot of talent and I guess over the years I've probably worked with a somewhat higher percentage of performing artists in my private practice than other psychotherapists, and I've seen certain themes repeat, that seem to get in the way of people being able to improvise well. One is this control issue that I mentioned. Another theme is the fear of failure. People who have tremendous concerns about public humiliation, that they're going to do it wrong and they'll be blamed, or that they'll never be able to feel good about themselves. It's hard to take a risk. Improvising music entails a certain amount of risk taking, if you really want to get into something new. You have to be willing to break new ground, you have to be willing to fall on your face, to make an error, and for that not to be disastrous. For some people psychologically that's scary territory. Then there's another whole group of people with a different theme that gets in their way, people who feel very guilty about being successful, which is actually a very common theme in human life. People who feel on some level they don't deserve to be

childhood that for them to be powerful and successful means taking it away from someone else: from a sibling or from a parent that was hurting or a father that was depressed. So they end up feeling they have to hold themselves back. These people operate as though there's a governor on their motor all the time. They're able to brilliantly snatch defeat from the jaws of victory. So those people have trouble getting up on the stage and letting themselves play as good as they can. They end up making mistakes, self-sabotage. In the course of psychotherapy they may be able to understand this theme and re-work it and get freed up and I've certainly had patients who were performers who have done just that. I mean one saxophone player I recall years ago who seemed to be getting criticized by the members of his band all the time because he wasn't playing well enough, but he brought tapes in for me to hear, and I could hear that he had tremendous talent. And in the course of our work it emerged that he felt very guilty that he was favored over his younger brother as he was growing up. Because of that guilt he felt he didn't have a right to be better than the other members of his band. It was as if he had siblings in his band, and he couldn't repeat this crime again. So he leveled himself, even put himself lower than his bandmates, even though he really was the best player in the band. And gradually over the course of psychotherapy he felt freed up from that belief and began to really unfurl musically, and he was out there on the bandstand kicking ass.

MR: Wow. That is very interesting. And how long would something like that take? It doesn't happen overnight for a person.

DZ: No it doesn't. It depends on how firmly entrenched the underlying belief is. And how traumatic the situations were when that belief was created in childhood, so that there's a spectrum. But you're right, it doesn't happen overnight. Sometimes you get quite a bit of change in a matter of months, sometimes it takes years.

MR: Wow. It seems to me you have to — especially classical people — you have to redefine what a mistake is if they're going to try to improvise. Mistakes — the definition of a mistake changes a lot from classical music to improvised music. But sometimes that's hard to — it's easy to say.

DZ: Yeah.

MR: That's fascinating. What's in the near future for you music-wise. I know you're working with Patrick.

DZ: Yeah that's one project that's going on. I've got a number of trio performances coming up in the next year, most of them will be with Buster Williams on bass and Matt Wilson on drums. I've been really enjoying playing with them. I've got two CDs in the can from our last performance at the Jazz Bakery last fall, and I'm currently trying to market those. And I've got a couple of labels that seem quite interested and hopefully that'll be out

before too long. I will be doing another west coast tour with Matt and Buster in the fall. In January I'll be at the IAJE convention with them.

MR: I'll see you there.

DZ: And we'll hopefully be doing some concerts around that. And then in the early spring, like maybe February or March, we're going to do a midwest tour and that should include a week at the Jazz Showcase in Chicago. Then I'll be going back to the Jazz Standard in May and doing some other East Coast things. Then in the summer hopefully some stuff in Europe. So that's the touring with the trio. I also do duets with David Grisman, the mandolin player. We did an album for his label, Acoustic Disk, that came out about a year ago. And he's wonderfully refreshing to play with. And so we do duet concerts periodically, you kind of get salted in among his quintet dates. And I look forward to that. And then I do a certain amount of solo concerts every year which is a special treat for me. I mean I love playing with people but there's also a special challenge and delight in being the whole orchestra, which a piano can do under the best of circumstances. So I look forward to that. And then I usually do a couple of presentations each year which I call Unlocking the Creative Impulse: The Psychology of Improvisation, where I talk about some of the issues we've talked about today, some of the psychological obstacles and what the nature of that merger experience is when you get into the music. What are some of the rituals and preparations one can get involved in that help usher in that state. And then I give examples at the keyboard and take questions from the audience. It's really a lot of fun. I do this sometimes for music schools or psychology departments, and sometimes for just lay audiences of certain groups who are interested in the creative process.

MR: If we had a nice grand piano sitting right here, and you sat down to improvise with no preconceptions in mind, how do you start? Is there something you decide to do to get started?

DZ: Usually what I try to do is to get out of the way. If I know I'm going to have to play, to get ready for a concert, usually what I try to do is to find a way to clear my mind of other concerns. Sometimes that will involve me getting off by myself for a few minutes before I go up on the stand. And if I'm worrying about where did I put my plane ticket, and did I call this guy, and what time is that gig tomorrow night, I try to gentle myself out of those concerns. And one of the ways that works best for me is an internal reminder, to remind myself how profoundly grateful I am to be able to play. That there is something about that that moves me so much, I mean even to say that brings tears to my eyes. It's like I do feel so profoundly grateful to have music in my life, that when I remind myself about this, the rest of these concerns just — they recede. And then I feel I'm ready to just greet

sit down and just wait for something to happen. And something happens. You know? There'll be — some phrase will occur, it will just play itself. And then I'm just playing. And then I just stay out of the way, I try not to manipulate the music. I try to honor it, to just listen to it. Where does this music want to go now? What am I hearing? And if I play a note or a chord or a phrase that contains something other than I was thinking about, an error in terms of where I was going, I try not to beat up on myself and start castigating — oh schmuck what a dumb note to play — because you start doing that and then that messes up the next four notes or the next four phrases and then you beat yourself up for that, and that could start a real downward spiral in the music. So I think over the years I've gotten better and better at being just graceful with that. I heard it, sometimes you make wonderful lemonade out of a lemon. You can take that mistake, turn it on its ear, do something very interesting with it, so that, and you talk to a lot of jazz musicians and a lot of them will tell you they've come to love their mistakes on record. Because it really pulled them into something different. Because they had to react in a different way, so you'd better legitimize it or work with it or do something with that clam that appeared in the line. So that's really ideally what my emotional state would be. Now being human I still have moments where thoughts intrude, get in the way, I'll be playing and I might be thinking about something else and I'll have to become aware that those thoughts have become intrusive and gently push them away, focus more purely on the music.

MR: Wow.

DZ: You know if somebody coughs in the audience, rather than seizing on that and getting angry at the coughing, to not even hear it, it just goes over one's shoulder.

MR: Does it help or hinder to think of the obvious places you could go? If you happen to land on a certain ninth chord and in your head you know the conventional place for this to go is here, does that even enter your mind, and if so do you try to ignore it?

DZ: I'm not really typically, when I'm playing, thinking about, ooh here's a C minor ninth which normally would resolve to — I'm not thinking that way at all. I'm having synesthetic experiences where I'm tasting the music, or musics have colors, different scales and keys have different colors for me and I'm playing and I'm hearing the blue and the orange together and it tastes kind of salty and rough, and I'm sort of awash in a lot of different sense impressions. And I'm just trying to follow what feels most authentic. Again, the idea of where does the music want to go, not where I want to put it, but where does this music organically want to evolve. That's what I'm hoping to allow to happen.

MR: It's a tall order.

DZ: I wish I could do it in a higher percentage of the time. But that's what makes it interesting.

DZ: Right. I mean that's the challenge of this thing.

MR: Wow. Well this has been a fascinating conversation for me.

DZ: Fun for me too, Monk.

MR: Good. I don't know if you have to be somewhere but we've talked for quite a while, so.

DZ: Well I'm fine to leave it here, unless you have any last questions you'd want to get into.

MR: Well I'll throw a couple of words or phrases at you, and see if they have any reaction. Duke Ellington?

DZ: I love the Duke's music. When I grew up though in terms of emotionally I was more drawn to Count Basie's band. And there was something about the rhythmic unison feeling of that band, it was like one pulsing organism, that emotionally got to me even more than Duke's band and Duke's writing, although unquestionably he's one of the towering geniuses of the music, clearly.

MR: Right. Okay. Ken Burns?

DZ: You know I didn't see that whole documentary. I saw some of the early ones and enjoyed learning so much about Louis Armstrong. A lot of stuff I didn't really know. So I was really pleased and I saw that as a big plus. From talking to my musical colleagues that apparently he left the last 50 years of music history for an hour and a half segment, I didn't even end up finishing it so I can't comment on the sweep of the whole work. I guess in his defense he never pretended that this was supposed to be a definitive balanced history of the music, but an evocation of what spoke to him. So Godspeed but from my own purposes, at least what I've heard second-hand, I do wish it had been more balanced.

MR: Okay. Can you define swing?

DZ: No.

MR: Would you like to try?

DZ: No.

MR: Okay. Most people say no and then they'll try. But as you said, go listen to Count Basie.

DZ: You see what you do is you point. Point at examples. And point when it's not happening. And then somebody with big ears could begin to say aha, I get it.

MR: What do you envision — I had said before I felt jazz seems to move so fast. Is it possible to measure where it will be ten years from now?

DZ: I don't really think so. Because you know we're about ripe for some incredible major innovator to come along, somebody of the status of a Coltrane. They don't come along that often. I think we're ripe for someone to come and just blow the lid off this stuff, and open up a whole new direction that we're not even imagining. I think that's going to be quite exciting when that happens.

MR: Lastly, were you familiar with the records "Ascension" and "Free Jazz," and I wonder

DZ: I loved it. I went through a period where I was doing only free improvisation and my concerts would be just that. And some of those free improvisations would have tonal roots in them and others would be totally pantonal or atonal. So I feel very open to that music, again, it's a question of how well is it played? How organic does it feel? One of the traps is, as George Russell has been quoted, is that the avante garde is the last refuge of the untalented. Because it'd be very easy for anybody to just pick up a horn and go — — — you know and say hey man, he's really into it. But how much musical substance?

MR: Right. No rules can be an excuse for a lot of things.

DZ: Right. So when that music is well played it's marvelous, I mean I love it.

MR: Well I want to thank you for your time today.

DZ: A pleasure, Monk.

MR: I hope you'll sign my CD.

DZ: It will be a pleasure for me.

MR: And next time I try to play "Quiet Now" I'll be thinking of you.

DZ: I hope you'll send me a copy of the video.

MR: I certainly will, absolutely.

DZ: Great.